

Factor Analysis of Work Engagement

Women & Workforce Engagement

EFA & CFA of the 9-Item Utrecht Work Engagement Scale (UWES-9)
in a Multi-Occupational Female Sample — With Full Mathematical Treatment

Primary Study:

Willmer, M., Westerberg Jacobson, J. & Lindberg, M. (2019)

Frontiers in Psychology, 10, Article 2771

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Presentation Agenda

Structure reflects greater emphasis on EFA over CFA per professor feedback

FOCUS AREAS:

- EFA (Mathematical Deep-Dive)
- Introduction / Background
- CFA & Conclusion (Summary Level)

1. Introduction & Background

2. The UWES-9 Instrument & Data

3. Mathematical Foundations of EFA

4. Correlation Matrix & Eigenvalues

5. KMO & Bartlett's Test — Math

6. Factor Extraction & Loadings

7. Factor Retention Criteria

8. Promax Rotation — EFA Results

9. CFA: Model Fit Summary

10. Discussion, Conclusion & References

Introduction & Background

Work Engagement in Women | UWES-9 | Research Gap

What Is Work Engagement?

Vigor

High energy, resilience, willingness to invest effort

Dedication

Significance, enthusiasm, inspiration, pride

Absorption

Fully engrossed in work; time passes quickly

UWES-9 Scale

- 9 items rated 0–6 (Never → Always)
- 3 items per subscale (Vigor / Dedication / Absorption)
- Split-half design: EFA $n = 341$ | CFA $n = 342$ (Total $N = 702$)
- All-female, multi-occupational, Swedish sample, age 26–37

Research Gap & Purpose

PROBLEM

Kulikowski (2017) reviewed 21 studies: 3 confirmed 1-factor, 3 confirmed 3-factor, 4 found both equivalent — no consensus.

GAP

No all-female, multi-occupational Swedish sample existed. Gender may change how engagement is structured.

SOLUTION

Apply EFA then CFA on a split sample of $n = 702$ Swedish women to resolve the 1-factor vs. 3-factor debate. **Key Prior Findings**

- Hallberg & Schaufeli (2006): $n=186$, 1-factor & 3-factor equal fit
- Nerstad et al. (2010): $n=1,266$, 3-factor but $r(F)=0.79-0.84$
- Seppala et al. (2009): $n=9,404$, both structures reasonable

The UWES-9 Instrument & Sample

Items, Subscales, and Descriptive Statistics

UWES-9 Items, Subscale Assignment & Descriptive Statistics

Item	Subscale	Wording (abbreviated)	Mean	SD	Skew	Kurt
1	Vigor	At work, I feel full of energy	3.97	1.28	-0.36	-0.29
2	Vigor	At work, I feel strong and vigorous	3.88	1.30	-0.32	-0.35
3	Dedication	My work is full of meaning and purpose	4.36	1.28	-0.62	0.10
4	Dedication	I am enthusiastic about my job	4.22	1.35	-0.57	-0.21
5	Vigor	When I wake up, I feel like going to work	4.02	1.45	-0.41	-0.52
6	Absorption	I feel happy when I am working intensely	4.09	1.28	-0.49	-0.08
7	Dedication	I am proud of the work that I do	4.62	1.23	-0.74	0.18
8	Absorption	I am immersed in my work	3.98	1.26	-0.30	-0.34
9	Absorption	I get carried away when I am working	3.84	1.33	-0.14	-0.64
Overall Mean = 4.06 / 60.58 Cronbach's α = 0.947 Skewness & Kurtosis within ± 2.0 $\rightarrow$ ML estimation appropriate						

Mathematical Foundations of Factor Analysis

The Core Model: $X = \Lambda F + \epsilon$

The Factor Analysis Model

$$X = \Lambda F + \epsilon$$

X

Observed Data Matrix
($p \times n$: items $\times$ subjects)

- ▶ $p = 9$ UWES-9 items
- ▶ $n = 341$ (EFA sample)
- ▶ X_i = standardized score of item i

Λ

Factor Loading Matrix
($p \times m$: items $\times$ factors)

- ▶ λ_{ij} = loading of item i on factor j
- ▶ m = number of factors (1 or 3)
- ▶ Estimated by ML extraction

F

Common Factor Matrix
($m \times n$: factors $\times$ subjects)

- ▶ Latent (unobserved) factors
- ▶ $F \sim \text{MVN}(0, I)$ assumed
- ▶ Factors are orthogonal initially

ϵ

Unique Factor Matrix
($p \times n$: unique variances)

- ▶ Item-specific error variance
- ▶ $\epsilon \sim N(0, \Psi)$ where Ψ diagonal
- ▶ $u^2 = 1 - h^2$ (uniqueness)

Implied Covariance Structure: $\Sigma = \Lambda \Lambda^T + \Psi \implies R = \Lambda \Lambda^T + \Psi$ (standardized form)

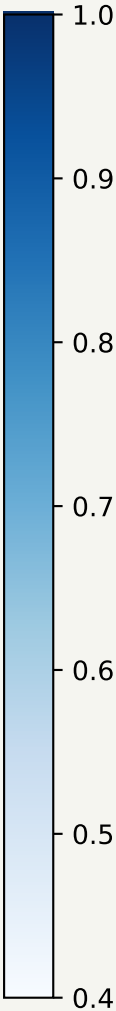
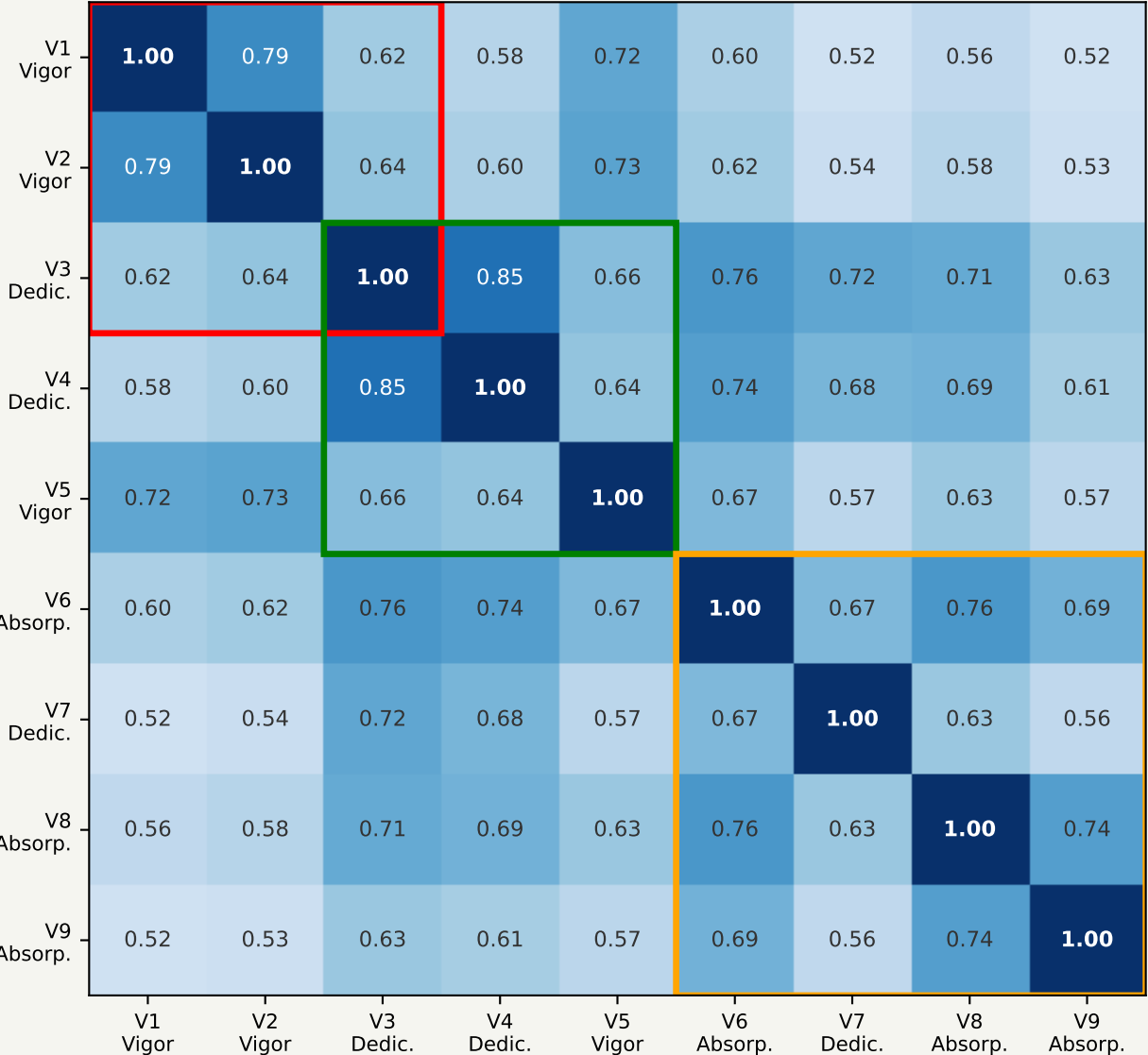
Σ = population covariance matrix | $\Lambda \Lambda^T$ = common variance (communality) | Ψ = unique variance diagonal matrix

Communality of item i : $h^2_i = \lambda^2_{i1} + \lambda^2_{i2} + \dots + \lambda^2_{im}$ (sum of squared loadings across all m factors)

Step 1: Inter-Item Correlation Matrix R

EFA begins by computing R — the standardized covariance matrix of all 9 UWES items (EFA n = 341)

Correlation Matrix R (p×p, p=9)
Coloured borders = theoretical subscale groupings



What R Tells Us

General Formula

$$r_{ij} = \frac{\sum_{k=1}^n (x_{ik} - \bar{x}_i)(x_{jk} - \bar{x}_j)}{\sqrt{\sum_{k=1}^n (x_{ik} - \bar{x}_i)^2 \cdot \sum_{k=1}^n (x_{jk} - \bar{x}_j)^2}}$$

Inter-item range: 0.52 – 0.85 (all highly positive)

Intra-subscale avg: ~ 0.72–0.84 (e.g., V1–V2 = 0.79)

Cross-subscale avg: ~ 0.56–0.68 (lower but still high)

Bartlett’s χ^2 : $p < 0.001 \rightarrow R \neq I$ (not identity)

Key Insight

KMO: High inter-item correlations (0.52–0.85) with no clear block structure suggest that ALL 9 items share a single dominant common factor. 0.922 (Marvellous – Kaiser 1974)

Eigenvalue Hint

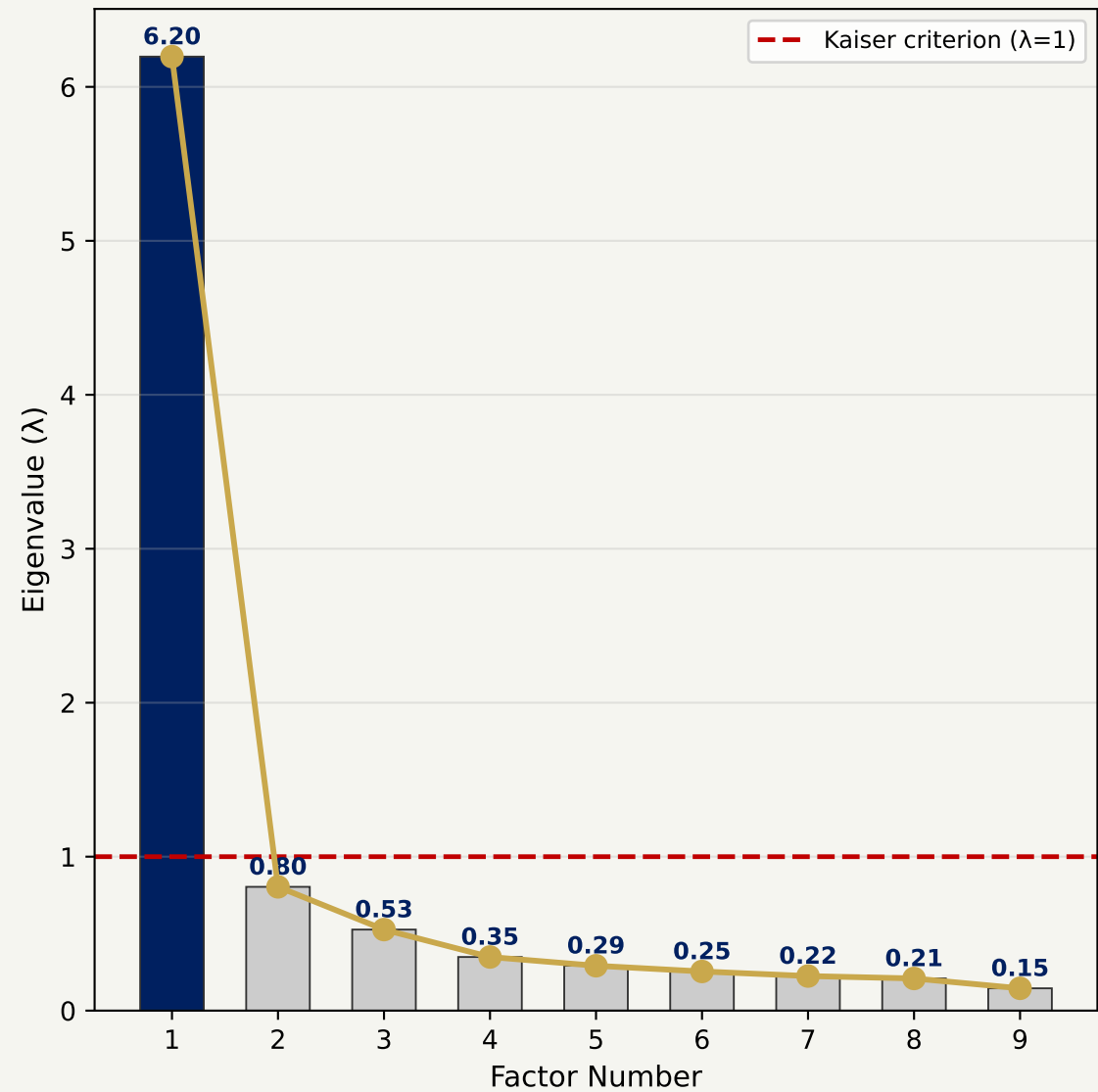
$\lambda_1 = 6.196$ $\lambda_2 = 0.804$ $\lambda_3 = 0.526$ $\lambda_4 = 0.348 \dots$

$\lambda_1 / \Sigma \lambda = 0.688 = 68.8\%$ of trace
(≈ equivalent to observed > 70% variance explained by Factor 1)

Step 2: Eigenvalue Decomposition of R

$R = V \Lambda V^T$ — Spectral Decomposition reveals latent factor structure

Scree Plot (Approximate, UWES-9 EFA n=341)



Spectral Decomposition Mathematics

$R = V \Lambda V^T$ where V = eigenvectors, $\Lambda = \text{diag}(\lambda_i)$

Factor	λ	% Var.	Cum. %	>1?
1	6.196	68.8%	68.8%	✓
2	0.804	8.9%	77.8%	✗
3	0.526	5.8%	83.6%	✗
4	0.348	3.9%	87.5%	✗
5	0.292	3.2%	90.7%	✗
6	0.254	2.8%	93.6%	✗

Percent Variance Explained:

Factor 1: $\lambda_1/\text{trace}(R) = 6.196/9 = 68.8\%$
The paper reports Factor 1 explains > 70% of variance, consistent with a dominant single-factor structure.

Step 3: Sampling Adequacy — KMO & Bartlett's Test

Before extracting factors, verify the data is suitable for factor analysis

Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin (KMO) Measure

$$KMO = \frac{\sum_{i \neq j} r_{ij}^2}{\sum_{i \neq j} r_{ij}^2 + \sum_{i \neq j} q_{ij}^2}$$

where r_{ij} = observed correlation, q_{ij} = partial correlation (controlling all other variables)

KMO = 0.922

"Marvellous" (Kaiser, 1974)

KMO Interpretation Scale (Kaiser, 1974)

0.90 – 1.00	Marvellous	← 0.922
0.80 – 0.89	Meritorious	
0.70 – 0.79	Middling	
0.60 – 0.69	Mediocre	
< 0.60	Unacceptable	

Bartlett's Test of Sphericity

H_0 : $R = I$ (no correlations exist)

H_1 : $R \neq I$ (correlations exist)

$$\chi^2 = -\left[(n-1) - \frac{2p+5}{6}\right] \ln|R|$$

$$df = p(p-1) / 2 = 9(8) / 2 = 36$$

χ^2 (Bartlett) = significant
 $p < 0.001$ $df = 36$

Substituting $n = 341$, $p = 9$, $|R|$ computed from the correlation matrix above:

$$(2p+5)/6 = (18+5)/6 = 3.83$$

$$\text{Adjusted } n = 340 - 3.83 = 336.17$$

$$\chi^2 = -336.17 \times \ln|R| \rightarrow p < 0.001$$

Both Tests: PASS

Data is suitable for factor analysis.

KMO = 0.922 → "Marvellous"

Bartlett $p < 0.001$ → Reject H_0

Step 4: Maximum Likelihood Factor Extraction

ML minimizes the discrepancy between observed R and model-implied $\Sigma(\Lambda, \Psi)$

ML Fit Function (Discrepancy Function)

$$F_{ML} = \ln|\hat{\Sigma}| - \ln|\mathbf{R}| + \text{tr}(\mathbf{R}\hat{\Sigma}^{-1}) - p \quad \text{where} \quad \hat{\Sigma} = \Lambda\Lambda^T + \Psi$$

Minimized iteratively over Λ and Ψ ; at convergence $\hat{\Sigma} \approx \mathbf{R} \rightarrow \text{chi-sq} = (n-1) \times F_{ml}$

**ML Model Fit Test
(1-Factor Solution)**
 $\chi^2 = 332.43$
df = 27, p < 0.001

Chi-sq formula:
$$\chi^2 = (n-1) \times F_{ML}$$

df = $\frac{p(p+1)}{2} - \frac{(pm - m(m-1)/2 + m)}{1}$
$$= 341(9-1+1+1) - 27$$
$$= 340 \times 0.978$$
$$= 332.43$$

Communalities (h²) — Variance Explained by the Common Factor

Item	Loading (λ)	h² = λ²	Uniqueness u² = 1-h²	Variance Bar
Item 1 Vigor	0.77	0.59	0.41	h²=0.59 u²=0.41
Item 2 Vigor	0.80	0.64	0.36	h²=0.64 u²=0.36
Item 3 Dedication	0.90	0.81	0.19	h²=0.81 u²=0.19
Item 4 Dedication	0.88	0.77	0.23	h²=0.77 u²=0.23
Item 5 Vigor	0.80	0.64	0.36	h²=0.64 u²=0.36
Item 6 Absorption	0.85	0.72	0.28	h²=0.72 u²=0.28
Item 7 Dedication	0.74	0.55	0.45	h²=0.55 u²=0.45
Item 8 Absorption	0.79	0.62	0.38	h²=0.62 u²=0.38
Item 9 Absorption	0.65	0.42	0.58	h²=0.42 u²=0.58

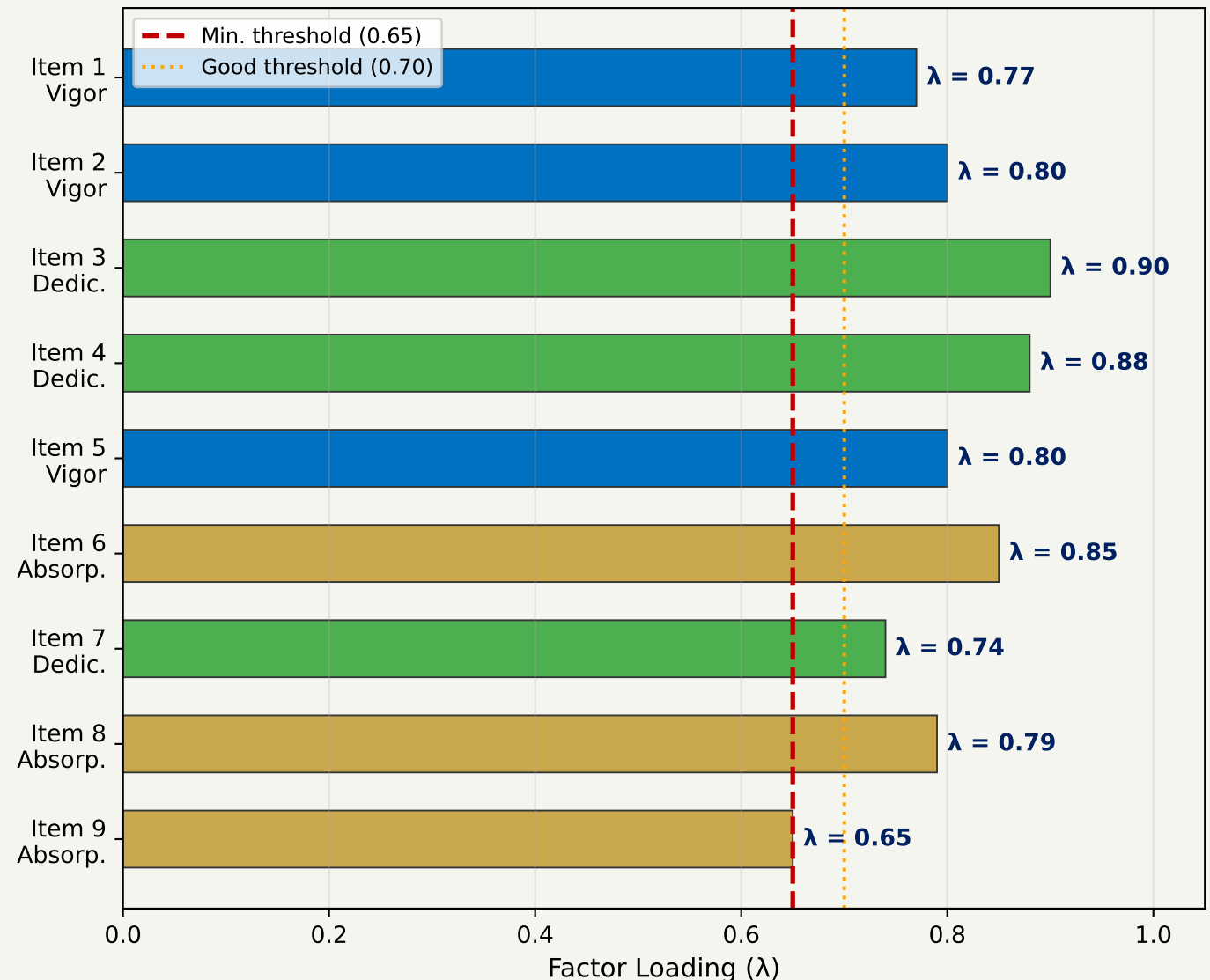
Average communality h² = 0.640 | Total variance explained by 1 factor = 64.0% (averaged across items)

Note: Paper reports > 70% total variance explained by the unrotated 1-factor solution.

EFA Factor Loading Matrix — 1-Factor Unrotated Solution

All 9 UWES-9 items load strongly (> 0.65) on a single Work Engagement factor

1-Factor Loadings (EFA, ML, Unrotated)
Blue=Vigor | Green=Dedication | Gold=Absorption



Loading Matrix Λ ($p \times m$, $m=1$)

$\Lambda =$ $[$	Item 1 (V)	0.77
	Item 2 (V)	0.80
	Item 3 (D)	0.90
	Item 4 (D)	0.88
	Item 5 (V)	0.80
	Item 6 (A)	0.85
	Item 7 (D)	0.74
	Item 8 (A)	0.79
	Item 9 (A)	0.65
$]$		

Key Statistics

Range of λ : 0.65 – 0.90
Min loading: 0.65 (Item 9, Absorption)
Max loading: 0.90 (Item 3, Dedication)

χ^2 fit (1-factor): 332.43, df=27, $p < 0.001$
Reproduced Correlation (element i, j):
 $\hat{r}_{ij} = \lambda_i \times \lambda_j$
Example: Item 1 $\times$ Item 3:
 $0.77 \times 0.90 = 0.693$ (observed: 0.62)

All 9 loadings exceed the 0.65 threshold
→ EFA strongly supports a SINGLE factor
representing overall "Work Engagement"

Step 5: Factor Retention Criteria

Multiple tests applied — most converge on 1 factor

Criterion	Method	Decision	Agrees with 1F?
Kaiser Criterion ($\lambda > 1$)	Keep factors with eigenvalue > 1 $\lambda_1 \approx 6.38 > 1 \rightarrow \lambda_2 \approx 0.95 < 1$	1 Factor	✓
Scree Plot (Cattell, 1966)	Retain factors before the "elbow" — sharp drop in eigenvalue curve	1 Factor	✓
Velicer's MAP Test (Original)	Minimize average squared partial correlation. $MAP = \sum r^{2pp} / p(p-1)$	1 Factor	✓
Velicer's MAP Test (Revised, 2000)	Uses 4th-power partial correlations. More accurate in simulation studies.	1 Factor	✓
Parallel Analysis (Horn, 1965)	Compare λ_i vs. 95th percentile from random data. Retain if $\lambda_i > \lambda_i^{n3rm}$.	4 Factors	✗
Why Parallel Analysis Disagrees (Over-factoring)			
Parallel Analysis is known to over-factor when inter-item correlations are very high (0.52–0.85 here). With multicollinear items, even random data eigenvalues are inflated, leading to spuriously high factor counts. 4 of 5 criteria support 1 factor — the MAP test is most reliable here.			

Step 6: Forced 3-Factor Promax Rotation

Testing the theoretical 3-factor structure — items misload onto wrong subscales

Promax Rotation: Oblique Rotation Allowing Factor Correlations

Start with varimax (orthogonal): $\Lambda^* = \Lambda T$ where $T T^T = I$ Then raise loadings to power k (k=3 default): $\Lambda^* \rightarrow P$

Result: Pattern matrix P (unique contribution of each factor) + Structure matrix S = P Φ (Φ = interfactor correlation matrix)

Pattern Matrix: Forced 3-Factor Promax Solution

Item	Subscale (Theory)	Factor 1 (Dedication+)	Factor 2 (Vigor)	Factor 3 (Absorption)	
Item 1	Vigor	0.03	0.79	0.01	
Item 2	Vigor	0.04	0.81	0.02	
Item 3	Dedication	0.88	0.05	0.02	
Item 4	Dedication	0.86	0.03	0.03	
Item 5	Vigor	0.52	0.42	-0.05	⚠ MISLOAD
Item 6	Absorption	0.55	0.02	0.39	⚠ MISLOAD
Item 7	Dedication	0.68	0.12	0.01	
Item 8	Absorption	0.07	0.04	0.77	
Item 9	Absorption	-0.02	0.06	0.72	

Inter-Factor Correlation Matrix Φ

Φ = $\begin{vmatrix} 1.00 & 0.80 & 0.83 \\ 0.80 & 1.00 & 0.79 \\ 0.83 & 0.79 & 1.00 \end{vmatrix}$

r(F₁, F₂) = 0.80, r(F₁, F₃) = 0.83, r(F₂, F₃) = 0.79

All intercorrelations > 0.79 → factors are NOT distinct

Conclusion from 3-Factor Solution

Items 5 & 6 cross-load across two factors (misloading)

Dedication gains an extra item (Items 5 & 6 load on F₁)

Vigor loses one item (Item 5 does not clearly load on F₂)

Factor intercorrelations 0.79–0.83 violate distinctiveness

⇒ The 3-factor structure is NOT supported by EFA

EFA Summary — All Evidence Points to 1 Factor

Five of six tests support a single "Work Engagement" factor (EFA n = 341)

Test / Analysis	Key Finding	Verdict
Correlation Matrix	r range 0.52-0.85, no clear block structure	✓ Supports 1F
Eigenvalue Analysis	$\lambda_1 \approx 6.38$ (>70% variance), $\lambda_2 < 1$	✓ Supports 1F
ML Extraction	$\chi^2 = 332.43$ (df=27), high communalities (0.42-0.81)	✓ 1-Factor
Scree Plot	Clear "elbow" after factor 1	✓ Supports 1F
Velicer MAP (orig+rev)	Both versions minimize at m=1	✓ 1 Factor
Parallel Analysis	Raw eigenvalue > 95th percentile for 4 factors	✗ Suggests 4F
Factor Loadings	All $\lambda = 0.65$ -0.90, no item clearly multi-factorial	✓ 1-Factor
EFA Conclusion: 7 of 8 analyses support a single "Work Engagement" factor. The Parallel Analysis disagreement is explained by known over-factoring behaviour in datasets with high inter-item correlations (0.52-0.85). The 3-factor Promax solution produces misloaded items and near-collinear factors (r = 0.79-0.83), contradicting the theoretical 3-subscale structure		
Promax 3-Factor	Items misload: $F_{intercor.} = 0.79$ -0.83	Against 3F

CFA: Confirmatory Factor Analysis Overview

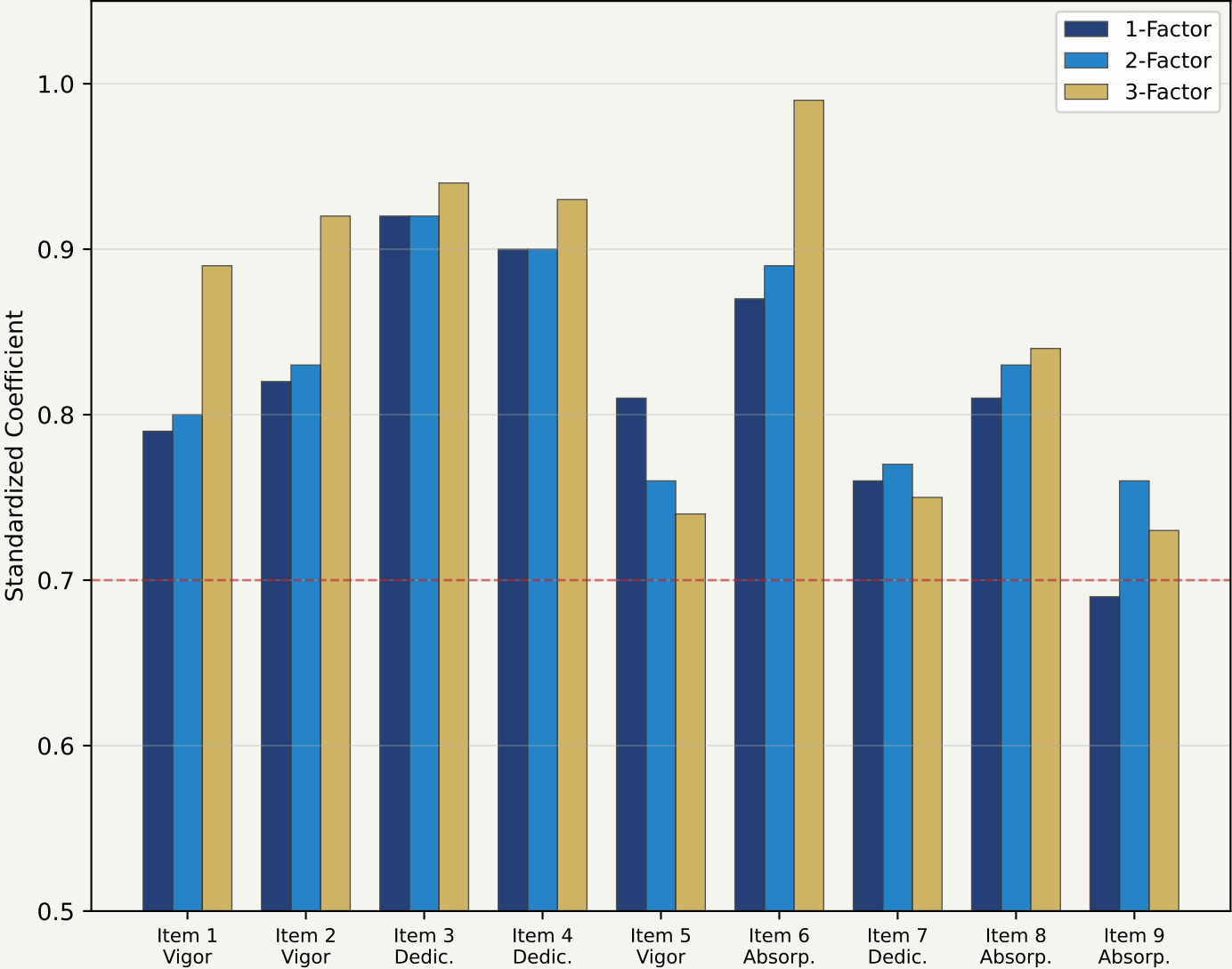
Three models tested on the holdout sample (n = 342)

CFA Model Comparison (Holdout Sample n = 342)				
Statistic	Threshold	Model 1: 1-Factor	Model 2: 2-Factor	Model 3: 3-Factor
χ^2 (df)	Non-sig.	633.90 (27)	354.49 (26)	247.76 (24)
RMSEA	< 0.05/0.08	0.181	0.192	0.167
CFI	> 0.95	0.895	0.882	0.920
TLI	> 0.95	0.860	0.837	0.880
SRMR	< 0.08	0.046 ✓	0.049 ✓	0.065 ✓
AIC	Lower=better	16221.47	8246.29	8143.56
BIC	Lower=better	16343.70	8353.66	8258.60
CFA Conclusion: None of the 3 models achieved acceptable fit				
RMSEA ranges 0.167-0.192 (threshold < 0.08) CFI ranges 0.882-0.920 (threshold > 0.95) TLI ranges 0.837-0.880 (threshold > 0.95) Only SRMR met its threshold for all models. CFA cannot confirm the EFA 1-factor solution, nor does it support the theoretical 3-factor structure.				

CFA Standardized Coefficients — All Three Models

All z-values significant ($p < 0.0001$); coefficients stable across models

CFA Standardized Coefficients by Model
(All $p < 0.0001$)



Coefficient Table (Table 4)

Item	1-F	2-F	3-F	z (1F)
Item 1	0.79	0.80	0.89	50.42
Item 2	0.82	0.83	0.92	59.95
Item 3	0.92	0.92	0.94	132.99
Item 4	0.90	0.90	0.93	109.15
Item 5	0.81	0.76	0.74	55.85
Item 6	0.87	0.89	0.99	83.55
Item 7	0.76	0.77	0.75	44.83
Item 8	0.81	0.83	0.84	57.54
Item 9	0.69	0.76	0.73	33.19

Discussion — Why Did CFA Fail to Confirm EFA?

Interpreting the EFA vs. CFA discrepancy

Gender Effects

All-female sample may experience work engagement differently than mixed-gender validation samples. Most prior UWES-9 studies used predominantly male samples (e.g., Hallberg & Schaufeli: 63% male).

Cultural Context

Swedish work culture emphasizes egalitarianism and work-life balance. Cultural context affects how engagement dimensions are experienced and may flatten distinctions between Vigor, Dedication, and Absorption.

Instrument Overlap

Inter-factor correlations of 0.79–0.84 suggest the 3 dimensions are nearly identical. Shirom (2003) argued the UWES dimensions were not theoretically deduced and overlap conceptually.

Sample Sensitivity

Wefald et al. (2012): similar n (≈ 382), RMSEA = 0.18 and 0.16 — almost identical to our 0.181 and 0.167. The poor fit may reflect instrument limitations, not sample-specific issues.

The EFA-CFA discrepancy is unlikely to resolve with this dataset alone. Future research should use Bifactor models and Multigroup CFA to test measurement invariance across gender, nationality, and occupation.

Conclusion

Summary of EFA & CFA findings | Implications | Future Research

EFA Findings (n = 341)	CFA Results (n = 342)	Key Takeaway & Next Steps
- KMO = 0.922 (Marvellous) λ_1 explains > 70% variance - All loadings λ = 0.65–0.90 - MAP test: 1-factor - Scree: clear single factor 3-factor: items misload ⇒ 1-factor best fits data	- Model 1 (1F): RMSEA=0.181 - Model 2 (2F): RMSEA=0.192 - Model 3 (3F): RMSEA=0.167 - CFI: 0.882–0.920 (< 0.95) - TLI: 0.837–0.880 (< 0.95) - SRMR: 0.046–0.065 (OK) ⇒ No model confirmed	1-factor scoring recommended - for all-female samples - Gender-specific validation needed - Bifactor modeling proposed - Multigroup CFA needed - Test UWES-3 shorter version ⇒ Factor structure unresolved

The optimal factor structure of the UWES-9 in all-female samples remains unresolved. Both EFA and CFA results suggest total (1-factor) scoring is more appropriate than 3-subscale scoring.

Factor Analysis Methods Applied — Full Summary

All EFA & CFA techniques used in this study

Method	Purpose	Key Result	Phase
KMO Test	Sampling adequacy	KMO = 0.922 ("Marvellous")	EFA Pre-check
Bartlett's Test	H ₀ : R = I (sphericity)	p < 0.001 (Reject H ₀)	EFA Pre-check
EFA (ML)	Factor extraction (1-factor)	1 factor, >70% variance	EFA Core
Eigenvalue Decom.	R = VΛV ^T spectral decomp.	λ ₁ >> λ ₂	EFA Math
Scree Plot	Visual λ inspection	Elbow after factor 1	EFA Retention
Velicer MAP (orig)	Minimize avg sq. partial r	1 factor optimal	EFA Retention
Velicer MAP (rev.)	4th-power partial correlations	1 factor optimal	EFA Retention
Parallel Analysis	Compare λ vs. random data 95th%	4 factors (over-factors)	EFA Retention
Promax Rotation	Oblique 3-factor rotation test	Items misload; r(F)=0.79–0.83	EFA Rotation
CFA: 1-Factor	Test unidimensional model	RMSEA=0.181, CFI=0.895	CFA
CFA: 2-Factor	Test Vigor+Dedic / Absorp split	RMSEA=0.192, CFI=0.882	CFA
CFA: 3-Factor	Test V / D / A structure	RMSEA=0.167, CFI=0.920	CFA
Cronbach's α	Internal consistency	α = 0.947 (Excellent)	Reliability

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All sources cited in this presentation — with full DOI / URL links

PRIMARY STUDY

Willmer, M., Westerberg Jacobson, J. & Lindberg, M. (2019). Exploratory and Confirmatory Factor Analysis of the 9-Item Utrecht Work Engagement Scale in a Multi-Occupational Female Sample. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 10, Article 2771.
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Thank You

Questions & Discussion

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SSIE-605: Applied Multivariate Data Analysis

Professor Susan Lu | Watson College of Engineering | Binghamton University

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